Fiscal Year:	FY 2026	**Task Last Updated:**	FY 01/08/2026
PI Name:	Lundblad, Nathan Ph.D.		
Project Title:	Microgravity Dynamics of Bubble-Geometry Bose-Einstein Condensates		
Division Name:	Physical Sciences		
Program/Discipline:			
Program/Discipline--Element/Subdiscipline:	FUNDAMENTAL PHYSICS--Fundamental physics		
Joint Agency Name:		**TechPort:**	No
Human Research Program Elements:	None		
Human Research Program Risks:	None		
Space Biology Element:	None		
Space Biology Cross-Element Discipline:	None		
Space Biology Special Category:	None		
PI Email:	nlundbla@bates.edu	**Fax:**	FY
PI Organization Type:	UNIVERSITY	**Phone:**	207-786-6321
Organization Name:	Bates College		
PI Address 1:	Department of Physics and Astronomy		
PI Address 2:	44 Campus Ave		
PI Web Page:			
City:	Lewiston	**State:**	ME
Zip Code:	04240-6018	**Congressional District:**	2
Comments:			
Project Type:	Flight	**Solicitation / Funding Source:**	2013 Fundamental Physics NNH13ZTT002N (Cold Atom Laboratory--CAL)
Start Date:	04/01/2014	**End Date:**	09/30/2025
No. of Post Docs:	2	**No. of PhD Degrees:**	0
No. of PhD Candidates:	1	**No. of Master' Degrees:**	0
No. of Master's Candidates:	0	**No. of Bachelor's Degrees:**	0
No. of Bachelor's Candidates:	0	**Monitoring Center:**	NASA JPL
Contact Monitor:	Callas, John	**Contact Phone:**	
Contact Email:	john.l.callas@jpl.nasa.gov		
Flight Program:	ISS		
Flight Assignment:	ISS NOTE: End date changed to 9/30/2025 per D. Griffin/NASA-HQ (Ed., 1/20/25). NOTE: Contract number changed to JPL 1699891 per J. Callas/JPL (Ed., 8/29/24). NOTE: End date changed to 9/27/2024 per U. Israelsson/JPL (Ed., 10/20/21) NOTE: End date changed to 3/31/2022 per B. Carpenter/NASA HQ (Ed., 1/4/2021) NOTE: New end date is 10/30/2020 per JPL (Ed., 5/21/19)		
Key Personnel Changes/Previous PI:			
COI Name (Institution):	Aveline, David Ph.D. (Jet Propulsion Laboratory) Vishveshwara, Smitha Ph.D. (University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign)		
Grant/Contract No.:	JPL 1699891 ; JPL 1502172		
Performance Goal No.:			

Performance Goal Text:	
Task Description:	Notions of geometry, topology, and dimensionality have directed the historical development of quantum-gas physics. With a toolbox of forces used to confine, guide, and excite Bose-Einstein condensates (BEC) or degenerate Fermi gases (DFG), physicists have used quantum gases to test fundamental ideas in quantum theory, statistical mechanics, and in recent years notions of strongly-correlated many-body physics from the condensed-matter world. We propose a specific program to explore a trapping geometry for quantum gases that is both tantalizing theoretically and prohibitively difficult to attain terrestrially: a quantum gas in a bubble geometry, i.e., a trap formed by a spherical or ellipsoidal shell structure, confining a 2D quantum gas to the surface of an experimentally-controlled topologically-connected “bubble.” The physics of a quantum gas confined to such a surface has not been explored terrestrially due to the limitations of gravitational sag; interesting work has certainly been done with gases confined to the lower regions of bubble potentials, but the fully symmetric situation has yet to be explored. The low-energy excitations of such a system are unexplored, and notions of vortex creation and behavior as well as Kosterlitz-Thouless physics are tantalizing aims as well. The solid-state modeling goals of the optical-lattice physics community are also fundamentally connected to the system, as the canonical Mott-insulator/superfluid transition features superfluid shells isolated between insulating regions. The central method to reach the sought-after bubble-geometry BEC or DFG is that of rf or microwave dressing of the bare trapping potentials provided by the Cold Atom Laboratory (CAL) “chip trap.” Radiofrequency dressing has been used conceptually through "rf-knife" evaporative cooling, but more recently through explicit construction of adiabatic potentials for interferometry, and shell-trap construction for both thermal and quantum gases. The proposed work is a window into a physical regime that is quite difficult to achieve terrestrially due to trap distortion; given the advantages of a microgravity environment, NASA CAL is uniquely positioned to realize the physics goals of this proposal.
Rationale for HRP Directed Research:	
Research Impact/Earth Benefits:	This work, while focused on the fundamental physics of ultracold atoms and not directly connected to human life, has a similar impact to life on Earth as that of all fundamental physics; it broadens our understanding of the physical world and helps us further cement our collective picture of quantum mechanics as "the way the world works." It explores the limits of how large Bose-Einstein condensates can be made, and to what extent the gravity-well of terrestrial labs render certain investigations difficult or impossible. The observations made aboard CAL through this project are a clear demonstration that physical insight can sometimes require microgravity facilities to be fully developed, and that spaceborne atomic physics experiments can be valuable contributions to our collective scientific efforts.
Task Progress:	The final period of this work (most of calendar 2025) was focused on planning and execution of ultracold atomic physics experiments aboard the Cold Atom Laboratory (CAL) with the "SM1" placeholder generation of hardware. The previous hardware experienced technical issues and was temporarily replaced with "SM1" hardware that produced ultracold samples through 2024 and was ongoing through this period. Residual sloshing amplitudes of transported ultracold traps were measured. [Ed. Note: The Cold Atom Laboratory is a facility for the study of ultra-cold quantum gases in the microgravity environment of the International Space Station (ISS).] Modeling efforts continued to focus on understanding the magnetic-field variation in the SM1 hardware and the effects on ultracold bubble formation. We have found the relevant radiofrequency (rf) resonances of multiple CAL traps and characterized their mechanical oscillation frequencies. Following an extended period of hardware unavailability, we found that rf-dressing for bubble generation was feasible on SM1 hardware and planned for rf-dressing runs in late 2025 / early 2026. Efforts will focus on demonstrating adiabatic transport and radiofrequency dressing into aspect-ratio ~2 bubble (in contrast to aspect ratio 3 or 4 bubbles of previous work). Dr. Lundblad was central planner of this work in this period, together with our partner at Jet Propulsion Laboratory (JPL), David Aveline, who, in addition to service as Co-Investigator, was our primary liaison to experimental operations aboard CAL. Postdoctoral scholars Gerent and Beregi at Bates College have supported the project through experimental planning and modeling. Theory Co-Investigators Smitha Vishveshwara and her group provided insight and support. The interesting phenomena that this project focuses on was disseminated in many research-group seminars, department seminars, conference presentations, and posters.
Bibliography Type:	Description: (Last Updated: 07/13/2026)
Articles in Peer-reviewed Journals	Lundblad N, Carollo RA, Lannert C, Gold MJ, Jiang X, Paseltiner D, Sergay N, Aveline DC. "Shell potentials for microgravity Bose–Einstein condensates." npj Microgravity. 2019 Dec 4;5(1):30. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41526-019-0087-y , Dec-2019